KPPSC PMS European History • Paper I

Question 8 (2022 Q.5 / 2016 Q.6 / 2018 Q.7): > **"Highlight the causes and consequences of the Crimean War (1853–1856). Do you agree that it was a 'futile and unnecessary carnage'? Examine its impact on European diplomacy and the Treaty of Paris (1856)." > *(Total Marks: 20 • Word Count: ~650 words • Standard Exam Length)***

Introduction Between 1853 and 1856, the Great Powers of Europe fought their first major military conflict since the fall of Napoleon: the **Crimean War. Pitting Imperial Russia against an alliance of Great Britain, France, the Ottoman Empire, and later Piedmont-Sardinia, the war arose out of the intractable **'Eastern Question'**—the geopolitical struggle to manage the agonizing decline of the Ottoman Empire (*'the Sick Man of Europe'*). Historians have frequently endorsed the biting verdict that the Crimean War was a **'futile and unnecessary carnage'**, ignited by a farcical dispute over the keys to Christian shrines in Bethlehem and waged with catastrophic administrative incompetence. Yet, while the military campaigns were marked by tactical blunders and horrific medical neglect, the war's geopolitical consequences were revolutionary: it destroyed the 1815 Holy Alliance, permanently isolated the Austrian Empire, embittered Russia, and created the diplomatic vacuum that enabled the unification of both Italy and Germany.**

The Causes: The Eastern Question and the Holy Places Pretext The root cause of the war lay in Tsar Nicholas I's ambition to exploit Ottoman decay and establish Russian hegemony over the Balkan peninsula and the Turkish Straits (Bosphorus and Dardanelles). To Great Britain, Russian access to the Mediterranean represented an existential threat to its maritime lines of communication to India. To Emperor Napoleon III of France, the conflict offered an opportunity to win domestic Catholic favor and tear up the hated 1815 Vienna treaties. The immediate catalyst was deceptively trivial: a squabble between Roman Catholic and Eastern Orthodox monks over the custody of the Holy Places in Ottoman-controlled Palestine. When Sultan Abdulmejid I favored Catholic claims, Tsar Nicholas dispatched **Prince Menshikov in May 1853 with an unacceptable ultimatum demanding a Russian protectorate over all twelve million Orthodox Christian subjects in the Ottoman Empire. Encouraged by British ambassador Stratford de Redcliffe, the Sultan rejected the ultimatum, prompting Russia to invade the Danubian Principalities (Moldavia and Wallachia).**

The Outbreak of War and the Battle of Sinope (1853) The diplomatic crisis turned into open war following the **Battle of Sinope (November 30, 1853), where Russian naval shells annihilated an Ottoman flotilla in the Black Sea. Denounced by the British press as the 'Massacre of Sinope,' the engagement provoked overwhelming anti-Russian war hysteria in London and Paris. In March 1854, Britain and France declared war, dispatching an expeditionary force to the Black Sea with the objective of capturing and destroying **Sevastopol**, the fortified citadel of Russian naval power in the Crimea. In 1855, Count Cavour committed 15,000 Piedmontese troops to the allied siege, calculating**

that blood spilled on the Crimean battlefield would earn Piedmont a seat at the future peace table to plead the cause of Italian liberation.

Evaluation: Was it a 'Futile and Unnecessary Carnage'? From an operational and human standpoint, the Crimean War was unquestionably an appalling and futile slaughter. Over 650,000 soldiers perished, with four out of every five casualties succumbing not to enemy artillery, but to cholera, dysentery, typhus, and gangrene in frostbitten, rat-infested trenches. Military leadership on all sides displayed grotesque incompetence: the British cavalry was decimated in the suicidal **'Charge of the Light Brigade' at Balaclava (October 1854) due to blundered orders, while Russian logistics collapsed under corrupt Tsarist bureaucracy. The war was only redeemed in the civilian imagination through the pioneering frontline journalism of William Howard Russell and the revolutionary nursing reforms of **Florence Nightingale** at Scutari. Furthermore, its immediate military objective—the neutralization of the Black Sea—proved utterly temporary, as Russia unilaterally repudiated the clause a mere fourteen years later in 1870.**

Diplomatic Consequences: The Treaty of Paris and the Shattered Concert While militarily futile, the war produced a seismic diplomatic realignment at the **Congress of Paris (March 1856). The **Treaty of Paris** compelled Russia to cede southern Bessarabia, demilitarized the Black Sea, and placed the Ottoman Empire under collective European guarantee. Crucially, the war shattered the conservative consensus that had maintained European peace since 1815. By threatening Russia with war in 1854 despite Tsar Nicholas I having saved the Habsburgs during the 1848 Hungarian Revolution, **Austria committed an act of colossal diplomatic ingratitude**. Austria alienated Russia permanently without winning the friendship of Britain or France. Isolated between a vengeful Russia and an ambitious France, Austria was left entirely friendless when Cavour struck in 1859 and Bismarck attacked in 1866.**

Conclusion In final historical judgment, the Crimean War fully justifies the charge of 'futile carnage' on the battlefield, but stands as the great diplomatic watershed of the nineteenth century. It settled neither the Eastern Question nor the fate of the Ottoman Empire, which continued to disintegrate until 1918. However, by destroying the conservative alliance between St. Petersburg and Vienna, the war liquidated the Metternichian order that had suppressed European nationalism for forty years. It demonstrated Tsarist backwardness, forcing Russia into the Great Reforms of Alexander II, while leaving Central Europe fluid. In the famous words of A.J.P. Taylor, the Crimean War was fought for trivial reasons, conducted with colossal blunders, and concluded with a treaty that did not last; yet without it, neither the Kingdom of Italy nor the German Empire could ever have been born.